

SPINAL CORD

THE NERVE FIBRES OF THE SPINAL CORD LINK THE BRAIN WITH THE TORSO, ARMS, AND LEGS. THE CORD IS MORE THAN A PASSIVE CONDUIT FOR NERVE SIGNALS. WHEN NECESSARY, IT CAN BYPASS THE BRAIN: FOR EXAMPLE, IN REFLEX ACTIONS.

SPINAL CORD ANATOMY

The spinal cord is a bundle of nerve fibres (axons) about 40–45cm (16–18in) long. It is only slightly wider than a pencil for most of its length, tapering to a thread-like tail at the lower (lumbosacral) part of the spine. Branching out from the cord are 31 pairs

of spinal nerves, which carry sensory information to the cord about conditions within the body and transmit the sense of touch from the skin. They also convey motor information to muscles throughout the body and to glands within the chest and abdomen.

